

SEXY MAD SCIENTIST GENDER METAPHYSICS

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Que(e)ry Collective / April 22, 2026

My interest in 1990s dyke-for-dyke erotica:

A delightfully perverse interpretation of “gender is the social meaning of sex.”

A material social basis of queer/trans gender practices (cf. “gender ideology”).

A surprising way to reconcile radical feminism, lesbian feminism, trans feminism, and feminism *simpliciter* (they are one and the same).

Trans meaning crafting: The creative, collaborative practice by which trans people construct interpretations of our bodies that make genuine sense of what they are and how they work on our own terms.

Mira Bellwether, *Fucking Trans Women*: “More than one of my lovers, in fact basically all of them, has at one time or another lamented that there’s no ‘instruction manual’ for my body. . . . I can sympathize. I’ve had to learn all kinds of stuff about my body on the fly that I would rather *not* have learned the hard way. I’ve had to invent words, metaphors, and stories, to explain to myself and to others how I think my body works, and what it can do.”

“There are a few principles at the heart of this zine. One of them is that we benefit from sharing knowledge. Another is that the form of someone’s body doesn’t necessarily determine what that body means, how it works, or what it can do. That is to say that just because what’s in my crotch *looks* like a penis doesn’t necessarily mean that it *works* like a penis. In point of fact it doesn’t, at least not most of the time.” (*FTW*, p. 2, my emphasis)

“Failure to hear me on that can have some pretty significant negative consequences; I dam up, I cross my arms. Being asked to fuck someone with my penis as a cock generally puts me off, and sometimes enough that I get angry or upset. I don’t understand the desire. Or I do, but I’m defiant: why ask for the smaller, unreliable, and most importantly *uncooperative* cock when there are plenty of dildos available? When I try to force the issue on my penis she is even more defiant: she basically crosses her arms as well, and things get difficult and annoying.” (*FTW*, p. 34, my emphasis)

“I knew early on that while I was into fucking someone with a cock, my penis was only into occasional cock-being. The rest of the time it would rather be a clit, and for the most part that’s how I treat her. She likes to be sucked, rubbed, all of the usual things. Really the only difference is size, the hole at the tip, and every so often she wants to get into penis-drag and fuck someone’s mouth, cunt, or asshole. In that way, we’re well-matched: I also enjoy occasional boy-drag. I think for both my penis and myself, the part that feels gross is the coercive *assumption* that because we look like we do, we should want to behave masculinely all of the time.” (*FTW*, p. 33, my emphasis)

“I also believe that one of the best tools we have at our disposal for figuring out our bodies, for learning about them and coming to delight in them, is experience. . . . I’m talking about *starting from data and working toward conclusions* rather than the opposite; something very much like sexy mad science (with lab coats and leather gloves optional).” (*FTW*, p. 2, my emphasis)

“Let the metaphors, the language, the analogies come afterward. They are helpful, but I believe with great conviction that what I have between my legs is not a metaphor or an analogy but something new and wonderful. Best to begin from the beautiful explosive moments of pleasure and discovery, and to let the rest come after.” (*FTW*, p. 3)

Inference to the best explanation (IBE): Given some phenomena and a range of possible explanations, if one explanation best explains the phenomena, then we have good reason to accept that explanation as true (even if its truth is not guaranteed).

Observations: It hasn't rained; the grass is wet.

Hypothesis I: It rained.

Hypothesis II: The sprinklers came on.

Hypothesis III: Grass does not get wet on its own without being rained on except at Columbia where laws of nature do not apply.

Hypothesis IV: Aliens visited Columbia to play water pistols.

The IBE account of trans meaning crafting: If interpreting a certain body part as a penis fails to fit and illuminate the relevant experiential data—including not just how a trans woman receives the ways in which others see and treat her, but also how she relates to her own body on her own terms—then that body part *is* not a penis, in the deeply empirical, old-school material radical feminist sense of 'is.'

Bellwether: "In this issue of the zine I am definitely going to be talking a lot about penises, and I am going to be using the word penis to talk about them. This is a *decision*, not an assumption or a given, so I want to say a few words about how and why I made it. Basically I needed a word to directly identify the sensitive, fleshy tube of flesh with all the nerves and blood vessels in it . . . not because I believe that's the *right* word for it. . . .

"Am I telling you that your body has a penis attached to it? No. . . . I made the choice to use the word penis because it's the word that most of us will recognize and understand, even if we only need to use it so that we can *replace it with a better one for our own bodies*." (FTW, p. 14, my emphasis)

An account of trans meaning crafting along these lines does *not* imply that there are thus universally correct interpretations of specific body parts; indeed, the fact that trans people interpret our bodies in beautifully varied ways is a data point that favors modeling trans meaning crafting on IBE.

Bellwether: "I would never tell another trans woman how to feel about her genitalia, I think I do want to invite anyone reading this, trans woman or otherwise, to try listening to the body more closely. It may be the case that your parts are telling you that they need to change in order to give you pleasure, or it may be the case that they are telling you things that you haven't paid close enough attention to hear. I hope that whatever is going on, you find your own strategies for working *with* your body rather than *against* it whenever it's possible. After all, it's rude to ignore a lady." (FTW, p. 34, my emphasis)

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Michelle Tea: "I believe that sex and writing can save people, especially queer people, because it shoots our lives up with hot, crucial meaning and gives us the power to create and recreate that meaning, even after the girl is gone and your heart is broken and your sheets are ruined forever" (introduction to *Best Lesbian Erotica* 2004, p. xiii)